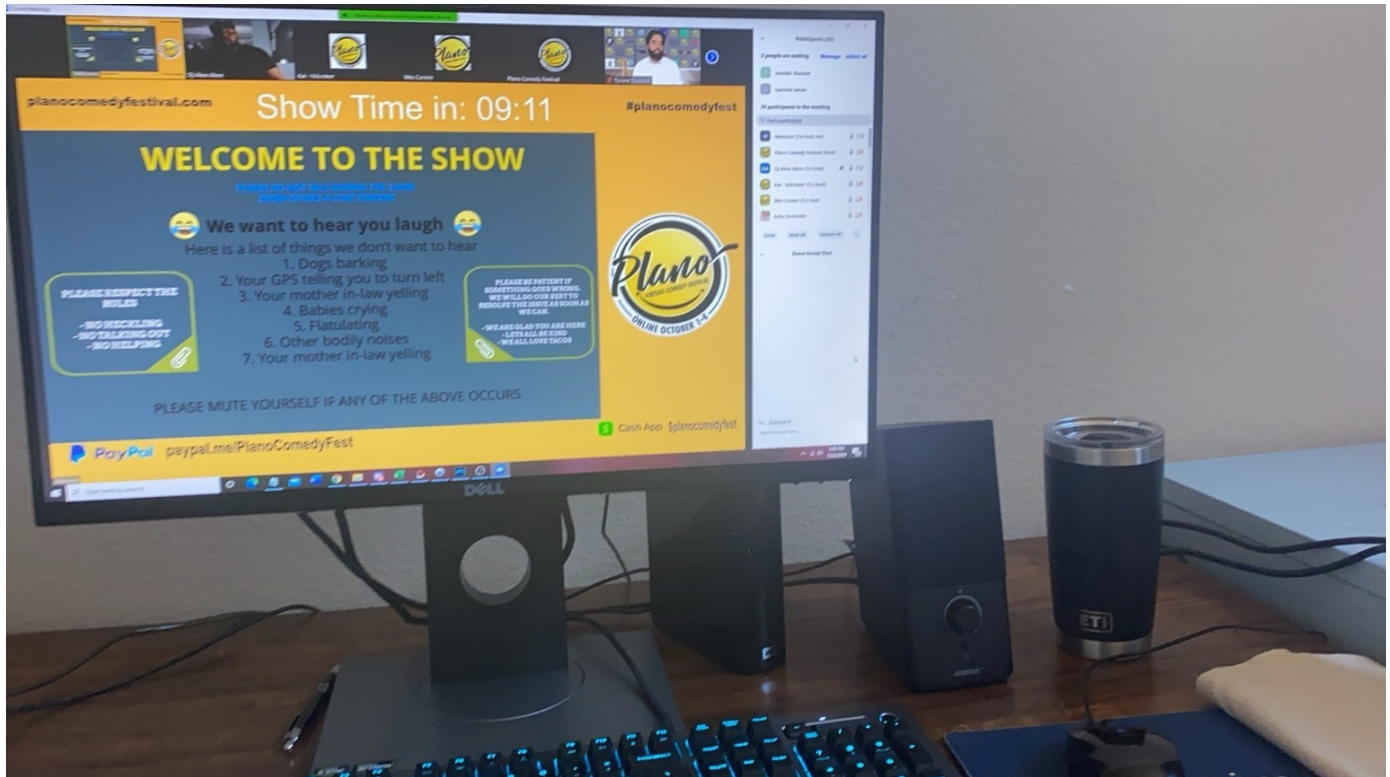


PLANO VIRTUAL COMEDY FESTIVAL

How a three-person team rebuilt a live festival for a remote audience during COVID-19



100+

PERFORMERS

21

STATES

4

COUNTRIES

17

SHOWS

4

DAYS

THOMAS SMITH

Board Member / Producer

OCTOBER 1-4, 2020

Plano, Texas -> Remote / International

The assignment: make it feel like a festival, not a Zoom meeting

When COVID-19 made an in-person festival impossible, the Plano Comedy Festival chose to go virtual instead of going dark. The challenge was to preserve the energy, structure and attendee experience of a multi-day live event while producers, performers, volunteers and audiences were all in different locations.

WHAT MADE THIS COMPLEX

The team was not handed a virtual-event playbook. We had to design the workflows, test the technology, educate performers and attendees, and deliver the program live.

MY ROLE

- Performer selection & programming
- Schedules & show logistics
- Website / digital QA
- Social media & promotional assets
- Virtual badges & show graphics
- Volunteer coordination
- Audience workflows
- Live Zoom / OBS production
- Roast Battle ring announcer

TRANSFERABLE FIELD MARKETING SKILLS

- Event logistics & program operations
- Registration / attendee workflows
- Cross-functional coordination
- Promotional materials
- Remote collaboration
- Vendor / partner support
- Accurate records & QA
- Live execution & troubleshooting



Branded virtual-stage environment.

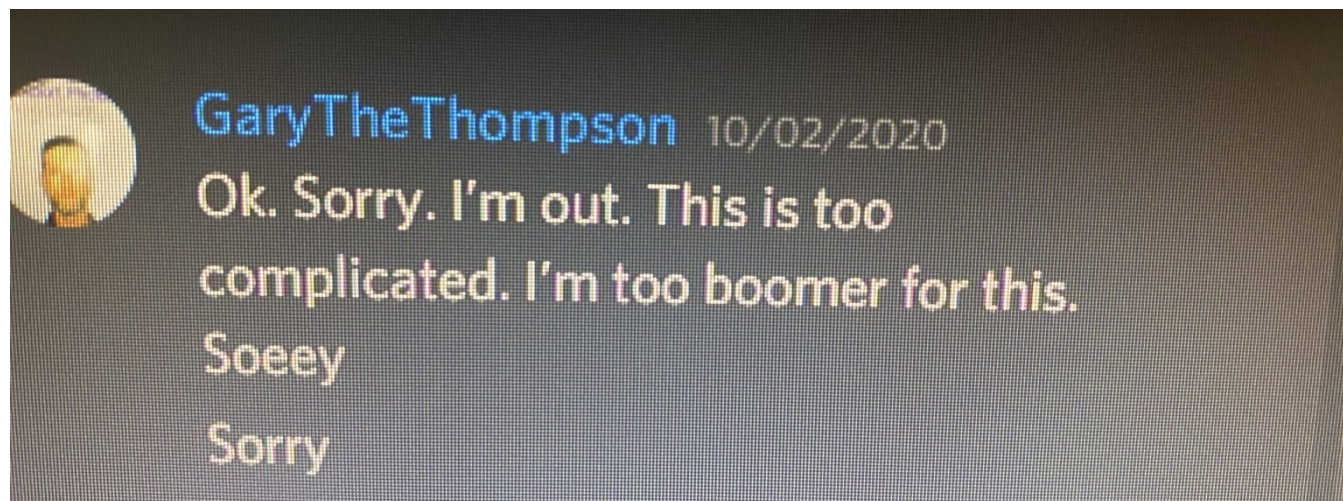


Live Zoom production with audience and sponsor visibility.

We recreated the front of house, backstage and stage - virtually

EVENTBRITE	WAITING ROOM	DISCORD	ZOOM	OBS
Registration	Arrival + education	Virtual green room	Live venue	Transitions + production

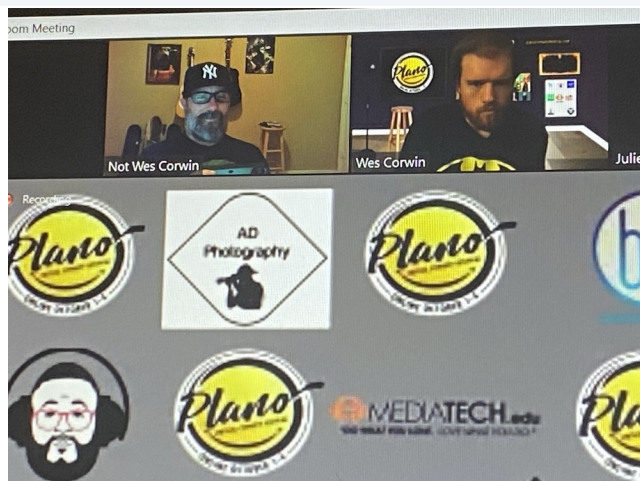
Audience members encountered a branded pre-show experience with a countdown and participation guidance. Volunteers managed check-in and background-noise issues. Performers used Discord as a virtual green room so they knew when they were on deck and could communicate with producers.



Audience education helped people understand how to participate in a virtual comedy show.

A COMEDY-SPECIFIC CHALLENGE

On Zoom, silence did not always mean a joke failed. We ran recurring virtual open mics before the festival so performers could practice the unfamiliar rhythm of online stand-up and receive lighting, video and audio recommendations.



Behind the scenes: home production station.



What the audience saw: a branded virtual performance environment.

One platform, many different event formats

The four-day program included showcases, headliner shows, late-night blue shows, musical comedy, sketch and alternative comedy, a free family show, workshops, after-parties and a tournament-style Roast Battle. A live DJ supported every show, including performer walk-on music.



Musical comedy required additional sound checks.



Specialty programming received show-specific promotion.



16-performer Roast Battle tournament bracket.

LIVE EVENT REALITY

- Bandwidth failures
- Different levels of Zoom experience
- Incorrect performer assets
- Audience noise / muting
- First show recording missed
- Rapid troubleshooting without stopping the event

The lesson: successful live events are not problem-free; they keep moving when problems happen.

Marketing was part of operations

The festival required performer badges, show posters, headliner graphics, sponsor placements, social content, pre-show slides and promotional video. Those assets had to remain accurate across schedules, performer information and event listings - an area where my QA background directly supported marketing execution.

The result: a complex remote event delivered live

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Contemporary reporting documented the festival's scale and international reach. The virtual format allowed performers to participate beyond the normal geographic limits of a regional festival, while the production team coordinated programming, communications, marketing and live execution across a distributed environment.

“You guys crushed this festival!!”

“Thanks to Britiany, Wes and Tom for all your work!!!”

“Great festival, great comics! Thank you guys for all the laughs; we all need it.”

“Y'all straight KILLED IT”

What I would bring to a remote field marketing team

- Ownership of event logistics and detailed follow-through
- Experience building registration, attendee and communication workflows
- QA discipline around names, schedules, links, data and digital content
- Calm live troubleshooting when plans change
- Comfort coordinating distributed teams and external participants
- Hands-on promotional asset and social media support
- Ability to learn unfamiliar event technology quickly
- Experience moving between behind-the-scenes operations and audience-facing execution

BOTTOM LINE

I helped turn an uncertain cancellation decision into a four-day remote festival. The work combined event logistics, marketing support, technology, QA and live execution - the same mix of precision and adaptability required in field marketing.

THOMAS SMITH | EVENT OPERATIONS • FIELD MARKETING SUPPORT • QA • VIRTUAL PRODUCTION

Public validation: Plano Magazine, Sept. 9, 2020 - more than 100 performers from 21 states and 4 countries; festival dates Oct. 1-4, 2020.